

FRANCHISES CASH IN ON INDIA'S HOT STREAK

In an era of Indian sports where franchise competitions dominate mainstream sports, and with the Indian men's team's performances in successive Olympics, it was a **no-brainer** for corporates to give HIL another go.

Aashin Prasad
aashin.p@thehindu.co.in

With the Hockey India League (HIL) returning in a fresh avatar after seven years, Hockey India (HI) will want to ensure that its second coming is smooth sailing.

For many years, former Indian players have spoken about the need for a robust domestic competition to aid the development of domestic talents. The announcement has been met with unanimous support from various quarters of the hockey community. "We have been waiting for so long for HIL to return," said India international Amit Rohidas, who had his breakthrough in 2013 with the league.

In 2024, none of the older corporates or owners is back, with seven new teams introduced in the men's league, except for Kalinga Lancers, which has been revived by Vedanta Limited. Four women's teams will compete in the newly launched women's HIL.

When the HIL initially folded in 2017, it was mired in issues, with teams facing financial burdens

resulting in salary defaults for players and staff and scheduling conflicts with the international calendar being the primary ones.

Between 2013 and 2017, the HIL was played in a home-and-away format in Mumbai, Lucknow, Delhi, Ranchi and Chandigarh. However, the 2024-25 men's and women's competitions will be played in Rourkela and Ranchi, respectively. Bhola Nath Singh, HI's secretary general and HIL governing committee member, pointed out that the biggest lesson for the league from HIL 1.0 was to adopt a sustainable approach, which is reflected in the decision to adopt two centralised venues for the relaunch.

The centralised venues with world-class infrastructure will help capitalise on the popularity of the sport, feels Divyanshu Singh, COO of JSW Sports, which owns Soorma Hockey Club men's and women's teams. The league recently announced it will offer free tickets for all the matches in both venues. "The first edition (2024-25) is happening in Rourkela and Ranchi, which have state-of-the-art stadiums, and hockey is very popular there. Hockey is not popular in urban India. I think that

was the mistake that happened last time, where you had franchises from urban India, but you were not seeing the kind of response, be it in ticketing or the buzz from the fans," said Divyanshu.

Madhav Krishna Singhanian, who owns UP Rudras, backed the current model of the HIL. "I feel what happened maybe in the past was seeing the success of the Indian Premier League (IPL), one tried to build costs as per the IPL. However, the revenues in viewership maybe did not come as per the IPL. So, for any league to become big, you start by having lesser costs. When there is more viewership, there is more revenue coming from broadcasting or sponsorship. Suddenly, you see the players' purses also increase," said Singhanian.

The HIL is a unique competition unlike any other in the hockey calendar. The top European male players ply their trade in their storied domestic leagues back home. The Belgian, German and Dutch top-division leagues, which operate over nine months, have a history of over 100, 100 and 50 years, respectively. Each league has 12 teams, with 22 matches played in a